bicameral legislative branch of the European Union's institutions and has been described as one of the most powerful legislatures in the world. The Parliament and Council form the highest legislative body within the EU. However, their powers as such are limited to the competencies conferred upon the European Community by the member states. Hence, the institution has little control over the policy areas held by the states and within the other two of the three pillars of the European Union. The EP has supervisory, budgetary and some legislative powers which were increased by the Single European Act, the Treaty of European Union (Maastricht Treaty) and the Treaty of Amsterdam.

The European Parliament has two meeting places: one at the Louise Weiss building in Strasbourg, France, which serves for twelve four-day plenary sessions per year and is the official seat, and the other, the Espace Léopold complex in Brussels, Belgium, the larger of the two, which serves for committee meetings, political groups and complementary plenary sessions. The Secretariat of the European Parliament, is based in Luxembourg.

The Parliament is composed of 785 MEPs (Members of the European Parliament), who serve the second largest democratic electorate in the world and the largest transnational democratic electorate in the world (342 million eligible voters in 2004). It is directly elected every five years by universal suffrage since 1979.

4. *Court of Justice of the European Communities:* The **European Court of Justice** (ECJ) is the highest court of the European Union. It has the ultimate say on matters of the EU law in order to ensure its equal application across all EU member states. It has the function to ensure that the Union's law is uniformly interpreted and effectively applied and has jurisdiction in disputes involving the member states, EU institutions, businesses, and individuals.

The Court was established in 1952 and is based in Luxembourg. It is composed of one judge from each of the member states. The number of judges at present is 27, but only 13 of them can hear a case at any one time in the 'Grand Chamber'. The Court is led by a President. Under the Single European Act, the Court is assisted by a lower court, the Court of First Instance, which has jurisdiction over